Q+A

Return of the Native

Chef **Gaggan Anand** has opened Raga, his first restaurant in India

Q. For years, you felt that India wasn't ready for you. Now you've come home and opened Raga in Delhi. Did India change—or you?
Both. And thank God. Delhi's diners are travelling, tasting, returning with different expectations. The young chefs here make me curious. I want to cook with them, learn, have fun, be part of it.

Q. You take a familiar *jhalmuri* or *nalli nihari* and pull it apart before putting it back together. Is there a line between reinventing a food memory and destroying the very thing that made us love it?
The test is what happens in your mouth. You can change the shape, temperature, texture, but something has to connect, that moment when you recognise a flavour and smile. If I need 10 minutes to explain why a dish is brilliant and you still don't enjoy it, I have a problem.

Q. Your food was always provocative. But rebellion that becomes popular eventually becomes establishment. How does Gaggan Anand rebel against himself?
By questioning the things that made me successful. Once everybody expects you to be unpredictable, even that becomes predictable. You can spend your life performing the same version of yourself. I get bored.

Q. How does the musical idea of a raga shape Raga's tasting menu?
I think about the meal musically: how it begins, where the intensity builds, when you need a pause. Twenty-two courses have to make sense together. One brilliant dish can still feel wrong in the sequence.

—with Bandeep Singh

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**